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MEDST 344 – Term Paper

Bergman's Swedish Psyche

Cries and Whispers is a vision of the past about visions of the past; it is a series of reveries and reflections, visions and memories, cries (suffering) and whispers (ghosts of the past) by which three sisters and their housekeeper are asked to reckon with their personal shame, repression, and abandonment. The main vision that envelopes the other visions is that of Agnes, a terminally ill woman, writing in her diary, then ending with an excerpt from Agnes' diary; it is a vision of gratitude, a warm memory –a rewriting of history – and love. It is this vision that Agnes wishes to share with her loved ones – her sisters Karin and Maria and their housekeeper, Anna, to offer them salvation from their suffering. It is Agnes' pained cries that trigger Maria and Karin's abandonment (Karin is abandoned, and abandons herself, and Maria abandons everyone else) and it is Agnes' loving whisper that could become the antidote; however, Anna is the only one open to perceiving Agnes' grace as an invitation. Abandonment inevitably becomes the main theme in Ingmar Bergman *Cries and Whispers*; superficially, it is a florid family melodrama seeped in grief surrounding Agnes' agonizing death, but beneath a portrait of the impassioned psyche of four women lurk other themes of emotional repression, spiritual fulfillment and salvation, relationships as functions of the soul, resurrection and rebirth, and acknowledgement of suffering as a pathway to healing.

Bergman began writing this film in the spring of 1971 during an isolating depressive episode. It began production that fall – despite Bergman's previous film success globally, he had to finance *Cries and Whispers* from his own savings, with investment from the main actors, and via financing from the Swedish Film Institute. In 1972 it was released to American audiences

and then in 1973 released to Swedish audiences. It seemed like a moment lost in a distant past time; a portrait of something that no longer seemed relevant, art for art's sake, perhaps. But Bergman isn't interested in the meaning of when but who and how – he presents a psychological snapshot of suffering and salvation that can be critically applied across time and space, although applies to his own time and space as well.

The political, economic, social, and industry climate from the inception of cinema leading up to the period in which *Cries and Whispers* was written and produced were wrought with particularly influential reform movements – labor reform, transfer of monarchist power to a bicameral parliament, a further shift toward social democracy until the establishment of the welfare state as policy, and women's suffrage. Culture evolved rapidly through the 1920s and 1930s, including adoption of the folkhem ideology as national brand, with an emphasis on the woman's centralized role in the folkhem. During this time, Swedish film also evolved into a tool for nationalist and ideological marketing, nationalist self-adulation, with a growing emphasis on the craftsmanship and visual art. Society was urbanizing, modernizing, secularizing, and arts and culture were the prominent forces of facilitating and recording change.

Bergman's childhood overlapped with this Swedish growth spurt, and he was no stranger to the dominant ideology of his time. His father was a Lutheran pastor, occasionally ministering to the Swedish Royal Court as an advisor to the Queen. The Church's influence and authority is not to be understated in the case of Sweden; at the beginning of the 20th century, national identity had long been tied to the Church of Sweden and held in high esteem culturally. Prior to the urban expansion of the early 1900s, many local rural governments were extensions of the Church, and the notion of a "state" church, woven into Sweden's borders since the Reformation, legitimized a wholeness of identity and culture, connecting communities, connecting eras, and connecting

borders. Even when Bergman was a child, Sweden was a fairly underdeveloped urbanized state relative to other major players in Europe, so communities were still small, heritage tied heavily into Lutheranism-as-identity and the homogeneity of culture as the folkhem mentality took hold and compliance and faith in the mechanisms of the state became a means of social engineering and stabilization. Right before Bergman launched his career – first in theater, as evidenced by his reliance on mise en scene as a storytelling device and the implication that so much of society, relationships, culture are forms of theater, masking one's true self – Sweden's development had a growth spurt; rapid industrialization and shifts in economic and political policies marked the period right before WWII, followed by a shift toward modest secularization and the establishment of the welfare state. It was first borne as a vision of the Swedish tradition of free farmers and proto-democratic early assemblies that would become the foundation for the notion of “folkhem”, or the people's home, where the mechanisms of the state would provide economic support and care for all its people. During WWII, Sweden's film industry blossomed as other European nations closed cinemas and production as consequences of war. It allowed a new global focus on a once tiny industry that could have been described as cultural branding and marketing for Sweden, and expanded the conventions of film toward more artistic, personal visions, paving the way for auteurs like Bergman to explore their “private nostalgia” via film. This period prior to the 1950s can be summarized as Sweden coming into a self-awareness of its newfound national ideology and developing a national identity of “egalitarian utopia” with intention, attempting to produce media and culture with an elevated sense of intellect and promotion of national issues, sometimes obscuring the mechanisms of history. It gets away with this distortion of narrative and erasure of history – namely its history of massive income and social inequality – due, in part, to the reform taking place via discourse, culture, and the arts as

opposed to bloody revolution or war; there have been no difficult, publicly humiliating lessons, no societal trauma, no gratitude for any of the individual suffering that generated the new future vision for Sweden and no compassion for an imperfect past.

By the 1950s, the results of the social democracy experiment proved fruitful economically, and the state system held the trust and faith of its citizenship. “housewife films” were produced and distributed in the national cinemas. The rhetoric promoted by these films correlates to the dominant ideology of the time; the *folkhem* is of utmost importance. The home is central to the family, and the *folkhem* is central to the home. The goal of these housewife films was to encourage the ideals of “happy, healthy home” – namely, the home is the *folkhem*, and the housewife maintains the home through child rearing, creating a home, chores and duties relative to children and marriage. These films emphasized the family as a chain, with every link playing an important role that lends strength and support to the chain as a whole, although, again, the housewife was the direct target of these films, the implication being that next to the paternal wisdom of the “patriarch” or welfare state, the housewife is the second most important social engineer in Sweden’s new world. These films were also an opportunity to advertise modernity; it implies that the core of *folkhem* is two parts – a vision of the future that we are both living in currently and facing toward, and this vision is not just about spiritual and emotional fulfillment, but material fulfillment as well.

It is no surprise that by the 1960s, with emergent global and domestic social and sexual revolutions, there was growing disillusionment with the welfare state and questions regarding its long-term stability. Cinema changed insofar as Bergman became renowned enough to be a litmus test for Swedish-ness, the term “Bergman-esque” taking root in cultural discourse as a descriptor for the seemingly gloomy, psychological knots he asks us to see in ourselves and untie. It is in

these decades that his films are not parsed for evidence of national identity but become a dimension of identity over time; they contribute to a cultural self-awareness facilitated by the gruesome vulnerability of self-reflection and acceptance. Typical Swedish films portray an idyllic landscape and bear a strong national connection to some political ideology or paternalist celebration of image; as Bergman became Sweden's most famous filmmaker, he upended the conventions of film as national marketing and turned the outward vision inward to explore the psyche. His films asked questions with broader implications regarding materialism and rationality as spiritual distractions and raise larger psychological issues than those that can be fixed with Swedish pride; his psychological provocations ask one to drop the mask and look honestly, authentically.

Broadly, these elements of Swedish culture – the nationalistic ritual of religion, the repression of oneself necessitated by homogeneity, the hierarchy, the folkhem and the mother figure, the revisioning of history – creep into the Cries and Whispers narrative, as an expression of auteur nostalgia and perversion of empty and ritualistic cultural norms. He does not conform to offering a celebratory picture of future Sweden via idyllic landscapes and characterized affinity for community but zeroes in on the broken psychological and physical post-utopian landscapes of his Swedish characters. He does not offer a future-facing, modern vision of the folkhem but gives us an intimate portrait of a lost past, in a home full of ghosts and symbols of class and economic hierarchy. The conscious effort is to explore a psychological ideology that transcends national boundaries; if we repress our suffering, if we abandon ourselves in our shame, we will not have compassion for ourselves or others. It is that compassion that offers relational healing and connection and a love that doesn't just exist in name or concept. Like all auteurs, he uses his voice to speak a "universal language" of personal themes that are globally

accessible, but he does so in a philosophical, intimate style that become representative of Swedish culture and filmmaking as it stands now.

Bergman speaks to his national culture and identity primarily by way of his characters experiences and personalities, specifically in religious themes; Agnes is a Jesus-figure, embodying a suffering that is free of ego and an offering of salvation to others who can accept it. But it is not her religiousness that imparts this grace onto Agnes; it is her willingness to be the sacrificial lamb so that her sisters might find wholeness in themselves and each other. He links spirituality with religion, although subtly argues the two are not one and the same. Agnes' depth of compassion transcends the confines of religion; the caress of her mother's face in her flashback suggests an awareness and forgiveness for the abandonment and alienation she has felt. She IS compassion and grace; her religion is secondary to that. Her suffering adheres to Lutheran concept of sacrifice and salvation; however, Bergman reconceptualizes traditional notions of salvation by way of the film's structure. Traditionally, the notion of salvation implies that it is for the benefit of the deceased; if that were the case, the film would end after Agnes' pastor gives a speech that underscores Agnes profound grace and compassion, almost holding her in god-like reverence. However, the film continues onward, not leaving the viewer to speculate about an afterlife. There is simply death; the concept of salvation is for the living, and it is an opportunity to confront the trauma of being alive and choose to live in grace. It is an opportunity to acknowledge suffering and heal. It is not about Agnes' resurrection, but the resurrection of connection; it is clear that insofar as Sweden's culture and church are inseparable concepts, for Bergman it is also inseparable from his psyche, although he takes the pieces of sacrifice, resurrection, and communion and translates them to a secular vision.

His use of religious symbolism and concepts of family and the home are culturally relevant, although he distorts the paternal nationalism and moral imperialism of Scandinavian filmmaking and portrays the family and home as wholly flawed. *Cries and Whispers* as a woman-led family melodrama is – not necessarily by virtue of any intentional commentary on behalf of national identity – seemingly as an answer to the Sweden’s “housewife films” of the 1950s-1970s. Their marketed, modernist optimism and emphasis on gender roles, particularly the emphasis on motherhood as social engineer in the welfare state, belies the suffering and circumstantial crises of reality; beneath the folkhem mythos is a world of pain and loss that needs to be reconciled. Although this narrative occurs decades before folkhem was uttered into public consciousness, the film was made around the end of the housewife film era. Agnes cannot be a housewife or center director of her home; she has cancer the organ that is her means of motherhood. Anna cannot be that either; she has had a child, but it is evident that child is no longer living, and she has lost her role as mother due to tragedy. Karin has a loveless marriage of convenience and stature; it is a transactional, childless relationship that is so lonely Karin cannot trust anyone to touch her, cannot let her guard down and heal. Maria has a child, but she is cold, emotionally unresponsive, her marriage is broken, and her daughter is absent most of the film. In Agnes’ flashbacks in the beginning of the film, she portrays their mother as being somewhat alienated from her, until she views her from a place of grace and compassion instead of ego or shame. It is suggested that her mother was emotionally unavailable, the implication being that perhaps she was alone and abandoned and passing that trauma of abandonment down to her children. The closest anyone gets to the identity of “mother” is when Agnes has passed and they have visions of her – Karin and Maria recoil from her as some gross dead thing, while Anna cradles her, Bergman posing them in *Pieta*, showing that Anna can embrace the trauma of lost

motherhood and revisit it to heal. She is not revulsed by Agnes' state and feels no shame in their connection, offering herself up as a Holy Mother.

Within *Cries and Whispers* there is also evidence of criticism of class hierarchy and a clear designation of who is more emotionally whole. Bergman seems to frame our more vulnerable characters – housekeeper Anna and dying Agnes – as more sympathetic and compassionate; given Bergman's middle-class upbringing, it could be pure coincidence that, in a culture that has celebrated the proletariat as harbinger of social change, these characters' humble traits are almost revered. Karin and Maria have access to material comforts afforded by their social stature, and both are married; however, beneath the polished surface is a profound misery and disconnect. Karin's transactional marriage will not get better; it is not a marriage of love. Maria's revulsion toward her husband is evident when he stabs himself and she refuses to go to his aid, and she is seemingly indifferent to Karin's loneliness and despair. It seems that the truly unhealthy characters are not the spiritual woman on her deathbed or her devoted and loving, "lower" class caretaker, but the others, who have material and intellectual comforts but are repulsed by the needs of the human soul. Despite his bourgeois upbringing, he seems to scorn the emptiness that accompanies these structures and hierarchies of authority and function; the last scene of the couples together highlights the meaningless ritual of their socialization, as they all pretend to be unmoved by the despair roiling within. The juxtaposition of these powerful, but empty, characters against society's outsiders – the working class, the sick – emphasize that wealth, social stature, emotional and physical unavailability are not salve for the suffering soul. We are all prone to shame in some way, regardless of circumstance; however, compassion and grace are the only antidote to suffering that can transcend space and time.

Despite the global understandings of wealth not equating to fulfillment, it does seem that Bergman is running critical commentary on the emotionally repressive nature of the welfare state. His formative years as a developing human and as developing artist witnessed a lurch forward in Swedish politics and culture that did not emphasize an embrace of history; if anything, the problem was having one foot in the present and one foot in the future, with no reckoning of the “sins” of the past. By juxtaposing metaphysical questions of suffering and salvation in connection against a backdrop of turn of the century wealth, it’s hard not to acknowledge that Sweden’s reform came about from a collective sense of national pride and coordinated reform messaging – it also happened as the result of shaping the narrative of history, that “nationalistic-marketing”, without fully reconciling the transgressions of the past. The reality is that economic inequality is, for all Sweden’s reform in the past 100 years, still the foundation from which this “egalitarian utopia” was born. This attempt to create a history by focusing on the future obscures the inequality, the injustices, and the suffering that generated real change; it does not heal by moving forward, it simply represses. *Cries and Whispers*’ intimate framing, style, chronology, and structure peel back the façade and ask us to look at the soul of Sweden as it was, not as it will be – and if it is the people’s home, then dissecting the psyche of the people is arguably a good gauge of the state of the home.

Bergman structurally and figuratively frames the segments of each woman’s suffering as a vision hidden inside of a larger narrative of Agnes’ passing and death; they are intimate “cries and whispers” sandwiched between stark red transitions and half-lit faces of the character they haunt. In these transitions, their faces are only ever half-lit, suggesting a split of psyche or a brokenness. The intimate setting, singular location, limited palette, and stark stringed instruments provide an inescapable assessment that this home is not well, and if this home is a symbol of the

people's home, then perhaps the people are not well or whole. The audience has perhaps spent too much time looking at the issues facing the collective, instead of looking inward, where those issues begin as individual crises; Bergman forces us into this intimate setting so that we can no longer repress the whispers of the past – or we can repress, but then we will be abandoning ourselves or someone else. It suggests, by using historical context, an abandonment of history – if Sweden is to heal its broken folkhem, it is not a matter of rational reform or material distractions, but compassion for its transgressions and an acceptance of its past, with grace in place of avoidance. For this homogeneous community, real connection is difficult to identify amongst the collective, but is found in a willingness to forgive ourselves and others for our individual shame.

Additionally, Bergman's use of historical context implies an intent to turn backward reflectively; the chronology of reveries and "looking back" to the past mirrors Agnes' vision in her diary, a rewriting of the past that doesn't alter the event itself but reshapes the feelings around the event – she is reborn, in this way, as a happy, loving memory. Bergman presents this "reframing" via gratitude and grace, giving history a new meaning that allows us – those who are left – to see ourselves and others in a new light, if we choose to face our suffering head-on and embrace our abandonment as an opportunity for grace instead of despair. In assessing the past, the assessment cannot be solely rational or solely material; it must humiliate to the extreme, with an emphasis on shame to the point of suffering, to come out through the other side reborn. This suffering and resurrection symbology in *Cries and Whispers* being lost on Maria and Karin as they stumble over an opportunity to see themselves better and revert back to their own protective mechanisms - Maria reducing the significance of her time with Karin to practically nothing and Karin recoiling from her affection as a result - suggests a failure to heal by slapping an ideology

over the brokenness of humanity and calling it utopia. In a broader sense, it feels like a schism between rationality and spirituality that leads to a lack of integration of self. This portrayal of brokenness is somewhat ambiguous in its symbolism; it is possibly a lack of integration of the individual parts of one's psyche or a lack of integration of the past and present. Bergman's themes are so universal, there is nothing presented in *Cries and Whispers* that cannot be digested by a global audience; it cuts right to the core of humanness by holding a mirror to our transgressions, showing where we hold shame and condemnation instead of compassion.

In any case, *Cries and Whispers* has become part of the canon of Scandinavian filmmaking and now part of the definition of culture; it is part of the mythos that Scandinavian cinema is dark, brooding, sometimes gloomy and intensely philosophical, notions generated mostly by Bergman, but also enhanced by the creative emphasis on filmmaking in Scandinavia – as a tool of communication, vision of idyllic landscape, or artistic personal critique of the culture of “nostalgia” that fails to reconcile the true past with the imagined one. The Scandinavian region in general saw massive reform, industrialization, and modernization in a short period in the early 20th century and these transformations were often people's movements; Bergman participates in a longstanding intellectual tradition of presenting the darkest corners of social convention in an effort to get to the root of humanity's spiritual crises and to reconcile our own dark corners. It is also a reflection of cinema's position in the arts; it is a product of technical craftsmanship as much as it is theatrical. The injection of financing into production companies via the state – the welfare state – gave Swedish film an advantage as it developed from technical craftsmanship and embodying literary tradition to personal artistic visions and exploration of genre. However, Bergman's film belongs to all of humanity, not just one singular national identity; this film seems to respond to national ideology by ignoring the demands of culture. If

anything, culture is the problem – or was the problem – and it must be reckoned with and not abandoned for the collective to be reborn. Cries and Whispers asks the viewer – whether Scandinavian or otherwise, regardless of time period or culture – to not turn away from their shame, to not recoil from their cries, and to not ignore their whispers.

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